

KF22 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Many of us are just now realizing the truth of KF Confession 5:

We attacked and cruelly suppressed our True Self and lost our true life.

When we notice that we are attacking and suppressing ourselves, or attacking and suppressing others, we can exercise our mindfulness muscles to help us recognize and disengage from the feelings, motivations, and behaviors of our self-hate. We can then use our KF tools to explore and reorient what we are experiencing. Both mindfulness training and KF tools help us reconnect with our True Self.

A KF member told this story about her lesson in mindfulness:

I offered to take a toddler for a walk, hoping that the mother would join me, but she just thanked me effusively and handed over the child. She was obviously very grateful for the break, but my plans had been scuppered, and my pride was hurt. I began to indulge my self-hate and wanted to cry. As I pushed the stroller, I tried to use my mindfulness training to recover from my disappointment but was not able to disengage from my feelings. Then I heard a little voice say, “Tree,” and a little later, “Bird.” At one point, she simply said, “Shoe fall off.” I realized that what I had been trying so hard to do, this two-year old child was doing quite naturally. She was completely in touch with her own experience and was able to mindfully observe the beauty around her.

The Self-Hate Massage

Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Bring to mind an area of your life that consistently stirs up self-hate for you. Perhaps you have made some mistakes, or perhaps your limitations have prevented you from achieving something. You might dislike your physical body, or you might wish that you were someone else. Let’s connect that hurt to our breathing and get acquainted with it using our new tools. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

CONSIDER

Take a moment to collect yourself within your present space. Sense the air or the clothing on your skin. Notice any noises. *(Pause for 30 seconds)* Now consider this area of self-hate. Notice the discomfort you feel when you think of it. Even though you hate this thing, allow it to rest inside your skin for one minute, without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

COMPASSION

As you breathe, experience yourself as a creature with limitations breathing in a material world. *(Pause)* You are not a god. *(Pause)* As you breathe in and out, imagine your area of self-hate moving in and out with the breath, massaging this place in your soul that is stuck or cramped. For one minute, give it and receive it with compassion. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

CLEANSE

Notice your entire body as it breathes. *(Pause)* Breathe with your mind, body, and soul as you open the doors of the prison cells of your shame, rage, regrets, and guilt. *(Pause)* Allow the clean air to sweep through those dark, stagnant places for one minute. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause.

Our prayer is based on Revelation 3:20.

Lord Jesus, You stand at the door of my life and knock. I am learning to hear Your voice and open the door. Come, Lord Jesus! (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION**0:21 TOOLBOX**

Our misoriented development often determines how we attack and suppress our True Self. If you are living with other misoriented people, you might try to identify their self-hate hotspots so that you can quickly recognize when they are in self-hate and gain a better understanding of why they do what they do, think what they think, and feel what they feel. Understanding helps you lovingly *stand* rather than react when the behaviors or choices of others feel so personal. Whenever you or another person turns away from the Idol's compulsive need to react, self-hate will inevitably follow. In order to maintain an oriented direction, you must be able to step back from the invitation to engage with that self-hate—whether your own self-hate or another's—and then endure the tension of refusing to repeat old patterns of behavior. That's why, in our KF training, we learn to endure before we learn to deal with self-hate. Self-hate will accompany every training opportunity in your process of redemption, so if you do not have the strength to endure the discomforts of self-hate, you will not be able to grow out of the pride system that drives your self-hate and determines your choices.

Every neurotic is vulnerable to self-hate. Self-effacing types are thrown into turmoil when they lose someone's support or take the biggest cookie. Mastery types hate themselves when they feel manipulated or helpless, when things don't go their way, or when they feel confused. Resigned types feel

acute anxiety and withdraw support from others when they begin to feel their feelings, take charge of their own development, or sense that the community requires something from them.

All of us are vulnerable to feelings of self-hate when we compare our present condition to our expectations of what we *should be* by now. Whenever we measure our present condition against these expectations, our real progress is judged as paltry or meaningless and therefore ignored, or even abhorred. Learn to recognize and hold in your mind the real progress you have made. The record of your **Meeting Preparation Guides** and spontaneous positive observations offered by trustworthy people are clear evidence of that progress.

We will now explore the cycle of self-hate and see how it creates havoc in our lives. I will also introduce two important allies, our internal parents, who are there to assist us when self-hate seems to have us by the throat.

The Idol's Engine of Self-Hate

When we are living in an artificial legal system, we cannot fulfill our natural design and real function; we are so intent on fulfilling our legal systems that we disregard actual conditions and realities and waste the potential of our productive energy. We abandon the natural flow of our design, and we manufacture a system of motivation that compels us to ignore possible consequences, rush our limitations, and constantly evaluate our performance, imagining ourselves to be sprinting home to an idealized glory. We hope that the sheer force of our effort will break down the barriers that confine us as limited and material creatures.

Fear is the strongest motivator that most of us know. It can push us to go beyond our imagined limitations and achieve things that without the power of fear we would never achieve. Fear helps us power through obstacles and override consequences. When we live in misorientation, this valuable emotion is pressed into the service of the Idol Self. Like any taskmaster who uses abusive methods to motivate and control another creature, the Idol generates fear by punishing poor performance with self-hate. Its victims are like slaves who have lost any sense of self-determination and are no longer free to make their own choices; their only aim is to avoid pain.

Our desperate desire to avoid the pain of self-hate drives our frantic efforts to perform to our Idol's exacting standards. The avoidance of self-hate becomes our chief method of self-motivation. But although we try desperately to avoid self-hate, we actually need self-hate to drive the engine of our Idol's search for glory. This is how it works. The stress of needing to perform, combined with little failures to fulfill the shoulds and claims of our legal system, causes the pressure of self-hate to build up in the cylinders of our soul. When that growing pressure becomes intolerable, any little event can ignite the pressurized self-hate. This flare up of self-hate leads to thoughts, feelings, and choices that temporarily relieve the tension of those piled-up failures. The feeling of relief is like that of an addict giving in to his addiction. There is even a kind of comfort and a sense of superiority in such a release, and we momentarily forget that destructive consequences will follow our choices. For a brief time we feel above consequences. We have surmounted all our limitations.

We use the pressure, tension, and flare up of self-hate to motivate us to make choices that comply with the standards of our Idol Self. Let's look at the example of one woman. Each little failure to fulfill her shoulds and claims increases the build-up of self-hate in her soul, and the tension of that self-hate is compounded by an unrelenting pressure to perform. Finally, although she is numb and cannot feel it, the tension becomes intolerable. A fairly insignificant event ignites the self-hate fuel that has been building

up. She may not be able to identify what event ignited the self-hate, but her behavior lets her know that she is in its grip. Suddenly she finds herself eating excessive amounts of foods that she knows will produce disastrous results, but while she is eating, she feels comforted and relieved of the tension. For a moment, she consciously feels that she is above the petty limitations of food and consequences and enjoys the euphoria of reckless choice. According to her Idol, she should be able to eat whatever she wants without any adverse consequences, and she acts as if the illusion were real. For a moment, she has fulfilled her Idol's search for glory.

Here are some other examples of how self-hate is used in the search for glory.

Certain events and small failures wound a mastery man's pride. He is so intent on maintaining his standards of performance that he is not aware of the pressure building up in the cylinders of his self-hate engine. Suddenly, a seemingly small event ignites the self-hate that has been growing, triggering an explosion of feelings. He is overwhelmed by a sense of injustice and, although he doesn't recognize it, fear. He instantly defaults to the habitual story that others—mostly his wife—are obstructing his path. He then uses the energy of the self-hate explosion to attack and control those around him. This release of tension feels good in the moment, and he recklessly prolongs the attack because it helps diffuse the excoriating judgment that he has been storing up against himself. This man's Idol demands that he control everything, so his self-hate engine drives him to grab control and behave in ways that would not be acceptable in any healthy relationship. His misoriented behavior, however, gives him a sense of temporary satisfaction: he feels that he is fulfilling his search for an idealized glory that includes abusing others without consequences.

A self-effacing manager drags himself through the conflicting perils of his career. He wants to please everyone, but he must also correct, evaluate, and even fire people. His bosses expect him to perform to certain standards that don't allow him to be the affable manager that his Idol Self demands. He compulsively needs to feel like the victim of circumstances and the choices of others, so each time he makes a leadership decision in his job, he must defy his Idol. Little failures to please everyone and create the most nurturing work environment for his team build up pressure in his self-hate engine. He also has a multitude of externalized shoulds. In his mind, everyone should treat him kindly and fairly and the workplace should be a fair and equitable experience for all. He claims that he is an exceptional manager and believes that if everyone did things his way, he would be able to achieve a friendly environment for his workers. Day after day, life does not support his illusions about himself and his world view, so his legal system of shoulds and claims is continually violated. He begins to feel exhausted and discouraged. Of course, according to his Idol, he should not feel exhausted and discouraged, and his failure to fulfill that should adds fuel to his self-hate engine. He sees himself as a victim of everyone else's refusal to comply with his beliefs and hates himself for not being able to make people love and appreciate him. An insignificant event in the form of another manager's choice is "the straw that breaks the camel's back". The event ignites his self-hate engine, and he falls to pieces. This breakdown relieves him of the responsibility to explore his potential. He was never really interested in developing self-determination or personal power, and now he can justify avoiding that terrifying prospect. He becomes chronically ill and refuses help. He makes choices that undermine his relationships and his career, and he demands that others feel sorry for him and take care of him. He has achieved the full victim status of the self-effacing Idol Self. He now can self-righteously blame the world for what it did to him.

Inevitably, there are consequences when we relieve the tension of pressurized self-hate through engaging in misoriented behavior. We doubt our own value and hopelessly deplore our weakness. We lose connection with our Creator, and we feel abandoned or alone. Deep down, we know that if we come to

our senses and courageously consider what we have done, we will feel shame and hurt pride, and it's the fear of feeling shame and hurt pride that often prevents us from choosing the path of humility and healing.

Our self-judgment and self-condemnation are painful and sometimes debilitating and shake our self-esteem. We are then left feeling empty and full of fear. Although we may not be aware of these emotions, we are at least aware that we cannot function in certain areas of our lives. How do we keep going? We consciously or unconsciously vow to work harder to fulfill all the shoulds and claims that caused the build-up of self-hate in the first place, and we demand that others comply with our efforts. However, we can never fulfill our Idol's standards of perfection, so we will inevitably fail again. The cylinders of our self-hate engine will fill up with more fuel, and the tension will once more become intolerable until it is ignited by an event—often one that is insignificant and that we do not even register. We grab at the immediate relief from the tension and use the energy of exploded fuel to drive us toward our imagined glory. We cannot possibly choose an oriented path in the moment when the self-hate engine fires. Instead, we are driven by an explosion of energy, relief, and the euphoria of having surmounted limitations. Our choices will no longer be the result of rational consideration but, like a physical reaction to pain, will be compulsive and pre-programmed.

We cannot hope to maintain our legal system and our pride and, at the same time, avoid the self-hate cycle. Self-hate is essential for driving the engine of our search for glory. In quick succession, we compulsively build up pressure with the fuel of our judgments, ignite that fuel which propels us on our search for glory, suffer the consequences, vow to do better, and then start the process again.

The alternative to self-hate is self-care. In orientation, we choose to abandon the pride system. When events reveal areas of pride, instead of mindlessly allowing fuel to build up in the self-hate engine, we confess our need for training and healing. We come to our Father, who is always ready to help us. We then show that we mean business by Asking, Seeking, and Knocking for solutions. We train and use our KF tools to regularly drain any fuel that might be building up in our souls. If there is no fuel to ignite in the self-hate engine, we can fight easy and make oriented choices when events or people create sparks. Without the intolerable pressure of self-hate, we can use our real free will to demonstrate our trustworthiness to God.

The Internal Parents

When you are in self-hate, your internal parents, father and mother, are your two greatest allies. These two archetypes can teach you self-discipline and self-nurture.

The father archetype stands up to protect and defend the True Self. He knows that training in self-management feels just as uncomfortable as any other kind of training, so he helps us endure our feelings while he directs our intellect toward training hard and taking action. He defends our minds and bodies from chaotic emotions, and when we are faced with the challenge of learning self-management, he encourages us to endure the inevitable sense of self-deprivation.

Building up the True Self is similar to building up our physical bodies, so doing a shoulds or claims worksheet could be compared to a workout at the gym or on the track. In our misoriented condition, we have allowed the muscles of maturity to atrophy, and now they are sluggish and whiny when we ask them to perform. When we refuse to engage in compulsive or addictive behaviors, it can feel like paddling hard to avoid drifting into a whirlpool. In fact, you will feel uncomfortable and may even suffer when you begin working on any kind of development, but after the workout you will have the satisfaction of having made an effort toward your goal. If you are suffering or stuck, rather than looking for immediate release from

the tension of your discomfort, take some time to observe your condition as you endure. Then, you might ask yourself, or you might even ask a father that you admire, *“How would an excellent coach or father direct me now?” (Repeat)*

Self-nurture is the internal mother. While the father keeps us on track in the midst of our suffering, the mother is caring for our needs. She tucks us into bed early. She gives us nourishing and even delightful food. She takes us for a walk and encourages us to breathe fresh air, and, like a gentle mother, she lets us cry our hearts out for a time or mope and fuss like an infant. Our internal mother allows us to have our feelings, but she does not allow us to abuse ourselves or others with those feelings. Our feelings are our feelings, and they are our responsibility.

This week explore your internal parenting. Observe your interactions with yourself within your own mind and observe your interactions with others. Consider how you were parented. That might give you some clues as to why you treat yourself and others the way that you do. When you are in self-hate, you might imagine what advice and encouragement an excellent father or mother would offer.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Loving Shepherd, be for me the voice of excellent parents. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

KF Confession 5 reminds us that when we attack and cruelly suppress our True Self, we create destructive consequences; we end up losing our true life. What would our lives be like if we accepted and cared for ourselves as God accepts and cares for us?

Let’s look at **Psalms 103**, which describes God as a loving father. I have expanded the meaning of this psalm by contrasting the demands and unmerciful retribution of the Idol Self with the kind intention and mercy of God. This psalm is a little long, so relax and consider just one or two ideas that resonate with you.

A psalm of David in praise of the Lord’s mercies:

¹Tell of the goodness of the Lord, my True Self,
And all that is within me, reveal His exceptional character.

²Tell of the goodness of the Lord, my True Self,
And forget none of His benefits (especially when I am in self-hate);

³The Lord, who pardons all of my iniquities (even when I can’t forgive myself),
The Lord, who heals all of my diseases (even when I can’t figure out how to stop being neurotic),

⁴The Lord, who redeems my life from the pit (even when I’ve dug that pit for myself),
The Lord, who endows me with lovingkindness and compassion (even when I can’t experience it),

⁵Who satisfies my desires with good things (even when I can’t recognize what is good).

His goal is to renew my original, created design so that I can soar like an eagle rising on its wings.

⁶The Lord performs oriented deeds (and hopes that I will do the same),
And He gives justice to all who are oppressed (crushed by the Idol's legal systems, pride, and self-hate).

⁷He revealed His good and beneficial support to Moses, His ability to guide and to help the sons of Israel.

⁸The Lord is compassionate and gracious (unlike the Idol, which is vindictive and demanding).

The Lord is slow to anger and abounding in lovingkindness (unlike the Idol Self, which is quick to wrath and abounds in compulsive egocentric reactions).

⁹The Lord will not always strive with our Idol Self,

Nor will He keep His anger forever (unlike the Idol, which must reserve a store of wrath and keep accounts of wrongs suffered).

¹⁰The Lord has not dealt with us according to our misorientation (unlike the Idol, which deals with us severely when we don't perform to its standards).

Nor has the Lord rewarded us according to our iniquities (unlike the Idol, which rewards us with self-hate when we fail to live up to its pride system).

¹¹For as high as the heavens are above the earth,

So great is the Lord's lovingkindness toward those who fear Him (who are more responsive to Him than to their Idol Self).

¹²As far as the east is from the west,

So far has the Lord removed our transgressions from us (unlike the Idol, which keeps those past failures ever-present and full of shame).

¹³Just as a father has compassion on his children,

So the Lord has compassion on those who fear Him (on those who want to do things His way).

¹⁴For He Himself knows our frame and its limitations;

He is mindful that we are only dust (whereas our Idol is only mindful that we should be God).

¹⁵As with all creatures, our days are like grass;

As a flower of the field, so we flourish,

¹⁶But when the wind has passed over it, it is no more,

And its place acknowledges it no longer (but the Idol is screaming, "Wait! What about the *Glory of Me!*? I am forever!").

¹⁷Though we are just dust, the lovingkindness of the Lord is from everlasting to everlasting toward those who fear Him,

And His orientation is passed from His children to their children,

¹⁸To those who are trustworthy and keep His covenant,

Who remember His do's and don'ts and are guided by them.

Take a deep breath.

The last part of this psalm reminds us of our creatureliness and vulnerability and, also, of the lovingkindness of the Lord, which never changes toward those who fear Him. What does fearing the Lord mean? It simply means that we are more committed to doing things God's way than we are committed to doing things our own way. We fear the Lord more than we fear the death of our Idol Self.

Our own orientation is the best gift we can give to our children, no matter what age they might be. Sometimes we may not want to work on our orientation for our own sake, but we may be willing to work on our orientation for the sake of our children.

Our goal is to be like the Lord who created us. He is mindful of our limitations as human beings, and He sees us as we are—creatures made of dust. The Lord wants to be on our side and support us in our true development, but as long as we are serving the interests of the Idol, He is forced to compassionately oppose us and wait.

Our bodies are like the flowers of the field, which quickly fade, and we feel that we have to fight for each moment. The Father, however, waits patiently and with great lovingkindness—forever. He knows that we are by design eternal creatures and that our natural habitat is in eternity. In this material world that is passing away, it is so easy to forget that we are by birth eternal beings, the children of a heavenly Father. We were created for happiness, and we can experience happiness at any moment in time, as well as in eternity.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Help me see things like You do, Father. Help me see myself like You do. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some clean water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider what it means to be an eternal being, the child of an eternal Father. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Choose from each section a few sentences that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you consider *what it means to be an eternal being, the child of an eternal Father*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Gently hold your experience in your awareness as you *consider what it means to be an eternal being*. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. Sometimes we flush feelings and thoughts from our consciousness before they have a chance to teach us. *(Pause)* Give yourself permission now to explore your thoughts and feelings without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider what it means to be eternal*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* For example, you might recognize what liberty or anxiety feels like in your body. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider what it means to be an eternal being*. *(Pause)* Do you judge eternity as good or evil? *(Pause)* What do you believe when you consider eternity? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something, or do you hope for something? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have had very strong feelings about eternity. We know this through archaeology and ancient texts. You are also a human creature and are not alone in your feelings. *(Pause)* When your feelings bring you information, you can choose what you will do with that information. *(Pause)* Breathe and allow some compassion to flow for yourself and for others who, as eternal creatures, are learning to manage this material experience. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful for this time of healing and training together. Help us explore our eternal nature as You guide us to our glory and to the truth about who we are. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our own lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self and all its limitations, with the rest of Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

If you would like more support for your KF training, you might consider mini-meetings. Ask your Karis Link about this tool or email admin.